

were the “in” thing and fantasy was the main theme. Going for a post-apocalyptic setting was something new, something that had never been done before. But Brian didn’t care, he had a vision, he wanted to end the world as we knew it(so to speak) and create “an RPG that broke the rules.” And so with the help of Alan Pavlish, and two well known pen-and-paper RPG creators, Michael A. Stackpole and Ken St. Andre, he set out to create Wasteland.

Come 1988 Wasteland finally made its arrival and boy did it arrive. A game where players felt like they actually had an effect on the world they were gaming in. There were multiple solutions to everything. You could recruit NPCs onto your team and they could refuse orders if they didn’t like them, and even ditch you if they felt your leadership failed to inspire them. They got rid of the RPG class system that was the standard and instead incorporated skills which you could level up. Wasteland was – and still is to some – considered one of the best games of the genre, a standard bearer if you will. It’s still often included in several “best games of all time” lists, and with good reason.

Now why are we talking about Wasteland when this article is about Fallout? Well it’s because Fallout is kind of the sequel to Wasteland. Yes yes, we know, “Why isn’t it called Wasteland 2 then?” Let us explain. So after the kind of success Wasteland got, everyone wanted a sequel, understandably. And Brian Fargo was all for a sequel, but he decided that Interplay didn’t need any major publishers and should just publish their own stuff. Starting with of course, the Wasteland sequel. However, there was teensy problem, the Wasteland IP belonged to EA and they had plans of their own for the franchise. But we don’t really care about that sequel. It’s called Fountain of Dreams btw, if you want to check it out. Never heard of it? Hehe. Interplay and Fargo had meanwhile started working on a sequel of their own which involved time travel and Albert Einstein as a playable character(what?). It definitely was not set in a wasteland, wouldn’t make sense for Einstein to be roaming around in a wasteland. How-

ever, the era of the Apple II – the intended platform for release of the game – was coming to an end. And the project was permanently shelved.

### **What? Oh noes! Where is Fallout then?!**

Don’t worry it’s coming. In 1994 Wasteland was enjoying a revival thanks to an Anthology CD celebrating 10 years of Interplay. News slipped out that Interplay was going back to the post-apocalyptic setting and it was initially being called Vault-13: a GURPS (Generic Universal Role-Playing System) Post-Nuclear RPG. It wasn’t exactly on Interplay’s priority list though. V13 was passed off to Feargus Urquhart, who ran an RPG focused subdivision in Interplay. He, along with the three project leads – Tim Cain, Leonard Boyarsky, and Chris Taylor – went back to the Wasteland-ish post-apocalyptic setting. They wanted the flexibility of a pen-and-paper RPG in their own character creation, where character stats and skills had a significant impact on how you played the game. You could learn skills, perks, and choose what path to take – sneak your way past or brute force your way through, you decided. They also made use of a karma and reputation system to track good and bad behaviour which would affect in game relationships and opportunities. Along with this of course was the 1950s setting we’re accustomed to now. This was also where we’re first introduced to Vault Boy, the iconic mascot of the Fallout franchise. It was decided that “Vault 13” didn’t really click as the title, so they

debated between two possible choices, one of which was “Armageddon”, however Interplay happened to have another project under that name so naturally the second choice won, and voilà, Fallout was born.

But the game wasn’t ready for release yet, there were still plenty of squabbles and problems. Eventually, thanks to those very squabbles, GURPS was replaced by S.P.E.C.I.A.L. (Strength, Perception, Endurance, Charisma, Intelligence, Agility, and Luck) at the very last minute. The stat system that we’ve grown accustomed to now, the system on which pretty much every other factor in the game hinged on, was reprogrammed in just two weeks. And finally, on September 30th 1997, Fallout was released for PC.

There was no team of Rangers this time, just a Vault Dweller, a simple man living in a nuclear shelter. He’s forced to leave the shelter in search of a water recycling chip replacement for his vault: Vault 13. And for that he must venture out into the unfamiliar and

